RECLAIMING VALUE

AFRICA'S STRATEGIC GREEN MINERALS AND THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF A JUST TRANSITION

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The promise of industrial transformation

Africa's rich reserves of green strategic minerals position the continent as a key player in the global effort to confront the climate crisis and advance green industrialisation. In the face of a deepening climate collapse, resources like chromium, manganese, lithium, copper, iron, and steel offer Africa a chance to accelerate its own energy transition and build new development pathways.

Yet this opportunity unfolds against a backdrop of economic vulnerability. Many African countries remain trapped in cycles of sovereign debt that erode economic sovereignty and narrow fiscal space for essential investments in health, education, and infrastructure.

Breaking the cycle of extraction and dependency

The legacy of exporting raw materials while importing finished goods has kept African economies at the margins of global value chains. We have become consumers of what we do not produce, and producers of what we do not consume. Breaking this pattern is not only an economic necessity but a moral and environmental imperative. The global shift toward green industrialisation offers Africa a rare chance to turn resource wealth into an engine for development and climate resilience.

The transformation must begin with local value addition. Instead of exporting raw materials, African nations need the means of implementation to process and refine minerals domestically, and manufacture higher-value products such as batteries, solar panels, and renewable energy components. This approach would create skilled jobs, boost government revenues, and strengthen resilience in global supply chains. Regional collaboration under frameworks like the African Continental Free Trade Area can help countries build shared infrastructure and harmonise policies to support beneficiation and green manufacturing.

Partnerships, policy, and political vision

To succeed, this shift requires political vision, strategic investment, and technological partnership. Africa must align its industrial ambitions with emerging global powers through platforms such as BRICS and China's Belt and Road Initiative, ensuring that these partnerships promote technology transfer, not dependency. The developmental vision must combine infrastructure investment with renewable energy generation to anchor a new model of South–South collaboration built on equity and shared prosperity.

But industrial growth alone is not enough. Africa's transition must be context-led, grounded in lived experiences, and designed so that local communities benefit directly through better livelihoods, fair labour practices, and environmental protection.

Africa failed to capitalise on previous 'mineral booms', emerging with limited industrialisation, sluggish growth, and fiscal crises triggered by falling commodity prices. It cannot afford to repeat those mistakes. Green strategic minerals alone will not make the continent a manufacturing powerhouse. A Pan-African industrial policy rooted in a just transition is essential to ensure that mineral wealth drives inclusive and sustainable development.

With the world's youngest population and vast renewable potential, Africa can lead by example in building a clean energy future rooted in equity. Strategic investments in education, research, and innovation will nurture the technical capacity needed to process minerals and manufacture clean technologies. By fostering regional value chains and green industries, the continent can lay the foundation for an integrated, resilient economy that serves its people first.

Turning resources into resilience

Africa's mineral wealth is not merely a commodity; it is leverage for transformation. By rejecting extractive patterns and embracing cooperative, value-driven industrialisation, the continent can move from being a supplier of raw materials to a producer of shared prosperity. The path forward lies in turning resources into resilience, ensuring that Africa's green minerals power not only the world's energy transition but also its own economic renewal.



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